

Technical Communication – Unit 1 Notes

1. Meaning of Communication

- The word **communication** comes from the Latin *communicare* → “to share, to impart, to exchange.”
- **Simple Definition** → Communication means **sharing information, ideas, thoughts, feelings, or values** between two or more people.
- It is a **process** (not one-time) → involves continuous steps.
- It is **dynamic** → keeps changing with situation, people, and context.
- It is **interactive** → needs both sender and receiver.

✦ Real-life Example:

When a teacher explains a topic in class, she (sender) speaks, students (receivers) listen, understand, and give feedback by asking doubts.

2. Process of Communication (Steps)

1. **Message** → Idea or information to be shared.
2. **Sender** → Person who creates the message.
3. **Encoding** → Converting message into symbols/words/signs.
4. **Medium/Channel** → Method used (phone, email, face-to-face, letter).
5. **Receiver** → Person who gets the message.
6. **Decoding** → Understanding the message.
7. **Feedback** → Receiver’s response that confirms understanding.

✦ Example:

Sending a WhatsApp message to a friend → you type (encode) → app sends it (medium) → friend reads (decode) → replies (feedback).

3. Purpose / Role of Communication

- To inquire, inform, persuade, entertain, request, or investigate.
- **Main Purposes in Organization:**

- **Flow of Information** → Right info, right person, right time.
- **Coordination** → Aligning staff efforts to achieve goals.
- **Learning Management Skills** → Managers learn by exchanging info.
- **Accepting Change** → Helps employees accept new policies.
- **Good Human Relations** → Builds understanding between workers and managers.

✚ Example:

A company announces a new policy via email (information), explains benefits in meetings (persuasion), and collects employee suggestions (feedback).

4. Features of Good Communication

1. Use simple and familiar words.
2. Sentences should be clear and easy.
3. Sentence length: 12–25 words.
4. Prefer **active voice**.
5. Be concise (avoid unnecessary words).
6. Avoid repetition.
7. Be accurate (facts + grammar).
8. Paragraph = one main idea only.
9. Use proper format (underline, bold, italics when needed).

5. Types of Communication

(A) Verbal Communication

- Communication using **words**.
 - Can be **Oral** or **Written**.
1. **Written** → emails, letters, reports, notices.
 2. **Oral** → face-to-face, phone calls, meetings, classroom discussions.

✚ Example: Classroom teaching is oral communication, while exam notice is written communication.

(B) Non-Verbal Communication

- Communication **without words**.
- Includes gestures, facial expressions, body language, eye contact, posture.

✚ *Example:* Smiling at a friend communicates happiness without words.

(C) Formal Communication

- Flows through **official channels** (hierarchy).
- Recorded, systematic, professional.

✚ *Example:* A manager sending performance appraisal to HR.

(D) Informal Communication (“Grapevine”)

- Flows **unofficially** (personal talks, gossip).
- Quick but can spread rumors.

✚ *Example:* Employees chatting in the cafeteria about promotion news.

6. Flow of Communication in Workplace

1. Downward Communication

- a. From **higher authority** → **lower staff**.
- b. Purpose: provide direction, control, instructions.
- c. *Examples:* Notices, circulars, emails from managers to staff.
- d. **Advantages:** Systematic info, strengthens authority.
- e. **Disadvantages:** Slow, too much formality.

2. Upward Communication

- a. From **lower staff** → **higher authority**.
- b. Purpose: give feedback, reports, suggestions.
- c. *Examples:* Suggestion box, grievance reports, employee feedback forms.
- d. **Advantages:** Encourages participation, gives useful suggestions.
- e. **Disadvantages:** May be filtered, sometimes ignored by superiors.

7. Horizontal / Lateral Communication

- Takes place **between employees of same rank or status**.
- Objective → teamwork + coordination.
- **Forms:** informal talks, gossip, phone calls, peer discussions.

Advantages

- Saves time & bridges departmental gaps.
- Employees feel free to share openly.
- Formal ideas can be discussed informally.

Disadvantages

- May create conflict.
- Wrong or incomplete info may spread.

✦ *Example:* Two project team leaders (same level) discuss deadlines over a phone call.

8. Diagonal / Crosswise Communication

- Takes place **between different departments / status levels**, bypassing hierarchy.
- Not bound by strict rules.

Advantage → Even lowest staff can share ideas freely.

Disadvantage → May harm relations with immediate seniors.

✦ *Example:* An accountant directly asks the HR manager for employee details.

9. Grapevine Communication (Informal)

- **Definition:** Informal communication during lunch, breaks, casual meetings.
- Called “**Necessary Evil**” → spreads fast, but can also spread rumors.

Positive:

- Builds interpersonal relations.
- Bridges gap among employees.
- Speeds up flow of info.

✗ Negative:

- Can create confusion.
- Sometimes spreads false rumors.

✦ Examples:

1. Team members discussing project updates casually in the canteen (helpful).
2. Rumor about salary cuts spreading through gossip (harmful).

10. Barriers to Communication

Definition: Anything that obstructs free flow of message from sender → receiver.

◇ Types of Barriers

1. **Noise** → unwanted sound.
 - a. Example: Loud DJ outside classroom.
2. **Physical Barriers (Channel Noise)** → technical issues.
 - a. Example: Mic disturbance, weak internet, poor handwriting.
3. **Semantic Barriers** → language/word meaning issues.
 - a. Example: “Bi-monthly” (confusing: twice a month or every two months).
4. **Psychological Barriers** → emotions, mindset.
 - a. Example: A sad person may ignore instructions.

◇ Classification of Barriers

1. **Intrapersonal Barriers** (inside the person)
 - a. Wrong assumptions → doctor using medical terms with patient.
 - b. Varied perceptions → hard work vs. manipulation for success.
 - c. Different backgrounds → North Indian vs. South Indian culture.
 - d. Categorical thinking → “I already know everything.”

2. **Interpersonal Barriers** (between people)
 - a. Limited vocabulary.
 - b. Emotional outbursts (anger, sadness).
 - c. Poor listening skills → hearing ≠ listening.
3. **Organizational Barriers** (within system)
 - a. Too many levels (message gets distorted).
 - b. Negative tendency (hiding info out of jealousy).
 - c. Wrong medium (e.g., sending confidential info via telephone).

11. The 7 C's of Communication

To make communication effective, messages should be:

1. **Completeness** → provide all info needed.
2. **Conciseness** → brief, no extra words.
3. **Clarity** → simple, clear sentences.
4. **Correctness** → facts + grammar correct.
5. **Concreteness** → definite, specific info.
6. **Consideration** → focus on receiver's feelings & needs.
7. **Courtesy** → polite & respectful.

✦ *Example:*

Email to professor should be **complete** (topic, reason), **concise** (short), **clear, correct** (no grammar errors), **concrete** (specific details), **considerate** (respect teacher's time), and **courteous** (polite tone).

12. Code and Content

- **Code** → group of symbols (words, signs, images) arranged meaningfully.

✦ *Example:* English alphabet is a code.

- **Content** → actual message chosen by sender.

✦ *Example:* "Submit assignment by 5 PM" is content.

13. Stimulus and Response

- **Stimulus** → anything received by senses that creates awareness.
- **Response** → reaction to the stimulus.
- Communication aims to bring **change in receiver's behavior**.

✦ *Example:*

Stimulus = Teacher asks a question.

Response = Student answers.

14. Stages of Communication Process (Detailed)

1. **Source (Sender)**
 - a. Plans & prepares message.
 - b. Must consider clarity, pitch, pauses, gestures.
2. **Encoding**
 - a. Message converted into symbols (words, images, gestures).
 - b. Wrong encoding may distort meaning.
3. **Channel**
 - a. Medium used → email, phone, face-to-face, video call.
4. **Decoding**
 - a. Receiver interprets the message.
 - b. Needs knowledge + attention.
5. **Receiver**
 - a. Should be mentally prepared to understand & respond.

15. Pronunciation & Phonetics

- **Pronunciation** = way in which a word is spoken.
- **Phonetics** = study of speech sounds.
- English alphabet = **26 letters**, but pronunciation uses **44 sounds (phonemes)**.
- These 44 sounds are divided into:
 - **Vowel Sounds** (Monophthongs + Diphthongs)
 - **Consonant Sounds**

(A) Vowel Sounds

- Produced without obstruction of airflow.
- Based on **a, e, i, o, u**, but with many sound variations.

Examples:

- /e/ → *dress, bed, head, many*
- /æ/ → *trap, cat, bad, mat*
- /ʊ/ → *foot, good, put*
- /i:/ → *fleece, see, tree, sea*
- /əʊ/ → *goat, show, no, know*

(B) Consonant Sounds

- Produced by obstructing airflow at some point (lips, tongue, teeth).
- Do not include vowels.

Examples:

- /t/ → *tea, tight, button*
- /d/ → *day, ladder, odd*
- /g/ → *get, giggle, ghost*
- /tʃ/ → *church, match, nature*
- /dʒ/ → *judge, age, soldier*
- /θ/ → *thing, author, path*
- /ð/ → *this, other, smooth*

16. Tone / Intonation

- **Tone / Intonation** = rise and fall in the **pitch** of the voice.
- Shows intention, mood, or approach of speaker.

◇ Types of Intonation

1. Rising Tone

a. Used in questions, requests, seeking clarification.

b. *Example*: “Are you coming?”

2. Falling Tone

a. Starts high, then drops. Used in greetings, routine talks.

b. *Example*: “Good morning.”

3. Falling–Rising–Falling Tone

a. Used in daily conversations for variation.

b. Keeps speech engaging and clear.

c. *Example*: “Well, I don’t really agree...” (voice goes down → up → down).

Important Difference Tables

1. Technical Communication vs General Communication

Aspect	Technical Communication	General Communication
Definition	Deals with professional writings: reports, proposals, manuals, research papers.	Literary and personal writings: essays, poems, stories, novels.
Purpose	To inform, instruct, explain clearly.	To entertain, inspire, amuse.
Style	Impersonal, objective, factual, precise.	Personal, subjective, decorative, imaginative.
Reply	Reader response is expected.	No response expected.
Vocabulary	Uses technical terms/jargon.	Uses general/common words.
Nature	Fact-based, logical.	Creative, emotional.
Use	Specific to professions (engineers, doctors, scientists).	General use in daily life.

2. Formal Communication vs Informal Communication

Aspect	Formal Communication	Informal Communication
Meaning	Follows official rules and channels.	Does not follow official structure.
Flow	Vertical (upward/downward) or horizontal.	In all directions (random).

Reliability	Reliable, authentic, recorded.	Unreliable, may be based on rumors.
Speed	Slower due to rules and hierarchy.	Faster and spreads quickly.
Examples	Circulars, notices, memos, reports.	Gossip, personal talks, grapevine.

3. Verbal Communication vs Non-Verbal Communication

Aspect	Verbal Communication	Non-Verbal Communication
Definition	Communication using words (spoken/written).	Communication without words (gestures, facial expressions, body language).
Forms	Oral (speech, meetings) & Written (letters, reports, emails).	Visual, gestures, signs, postures, tone of voice.
Clarity	More explicit and clear.	May be vague and depend on interpretation.
Record	Written verbal communication can be recorded.	Usually no permanent record.
Examples	Telephone calls, presentations, notices, emails.	Smile, nodding, handshakes, eye contact.

4. Downward Communication vs Upward Communication

Aspect	Downward Communication	Upward Communication
Direction	From higher authority to lower authority.	From subordinates to superiors.
Purpose	To instruct, order, inform, guide.	To give feedback, share ideas, express concerns.
Examples	Notices, memos, official orders, guidelines.	Suggestions, reports, grievances, proposals.
Advantages	Provides clarity of goals and policies.	Builds trust, involves employees in decisions.
Limitations	Time-consuming, may lose meaning at lower levels.	May be ignored by higher authority.

5. Oral Communication vs Written Communication

Aspect	Oral Communication	Written Communication
Meaning	Communication through spoken words.	Communication through written symbols/words.
Speed	Very fast, immediate feedback.	Slower, feedback delayed.
Record	No permanent record.	Permanent record available.
Suitability	Useful for quick discussion, instructions.	Useful for official, legal, formal communication.
Examples	Face-to-face talk, meetings, phone calls.	Reports, letters, notices, circulars.

6. Rising Tone vs Falling Tone

Aspect	Rising Tone	Falling Tone
Meaning	Voice pitch rises at the end.	Voice pitch falls at the end.
Use	Questions, requests, seeking clarification.	Statements, greetings, routine talks.
Effect	Shows doubt, expectation, curiosity.	Shows completeness, confidence.
Example	"Are you ready?"	"I am ready."